

ROUGH EDITED COPY

INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION

WASHINGTON OUTLOOK:
WHAT DIFFERENT WILL THE ELECTION MAKE FOR PERSONS WITH
DISABILITIES?
OCTOBER 25, 2018

REMOTE CART CAPTIONING PROVIDED BY:
ALTERNATIVE COMMUNICATION SERVICES, LLC
www.CaptionFamily.com

* * * * *

This is being provided in a rough-draft format. Communication Access
Realtime Translation (CART) is provided in order to facilitate
communication accessibility and may not be a totally verbatim record of the
proceedings

* * * * *

>> Good afternoon, everybody. I see people are starting to join the
webinar and get settled in while you are waiting for us to begin, which will
be promptly at noon central which is where I am at the moment and
1:00 p.m. eastern time. If you could just answer the question in the poll,
we'd love to know who is here today, what role you would cat gore guys
yourself as having, wand we'll get started in just a couple of minutes.

For anyone who is interested, the -- I'm pasting the link to the presentation
which is on our website, I'm pasting that in the chat. I'm also going to paste
the link to the live captioning. So if anyone is in need of either of those. It
looks like it is all one long link, but those are two links that I just put in the
chat so that people who would like to see what's there can access that
information. If anyone wants to use the chat to say hello and say what
country you're from, that's fine, while you're getting ready here.

>> Rebecca, will I be clicking on end poll?

>> I can do that.

>> It looks like 12 noon where I am, I know it's maybe 1 where a lot of people are, eastern time. Hello folks that are saying hi here. So my name is Rebecca Laso. I am the knowledge translation associate at Think College and today I'm pleased to welcome Stephanie Smith Lee who is going to be our webinar called Washington outlook, what a -- what difference will the election make for persons with disabilities? Sorry about that. Stephanie is the cochair of the inclusive higher education committee, served as senior policy advisor for the national down syndrome Congress, and shares the think College accreditation work group. We're grateful for Stephanie for joining us today. This time of year is very busy for Stephanie and many others, so we're especially grateful for her time.

I also want to let people know, like I said a moment ago, we are recording this webinar so that recording will be available in the next day or so on our website. I just put in the chat box a link to the live caption figure anyone needs that information. I'm also going to put a link to the event page on our website so if anybody would like to get the presentation and follow along that way, that's available.

What else can I tell you, Zoom, if anyone has any questions or technical problems throughout this webinar, you can contact me in the Zoom message box in the chat box. I will be here to help with technical issues. And Stephanie will take questions later in the webinar or at the end, but you can put them in throughout and I'll make sure that she gets those. I don't think that -- like I said, we're captioning, the presentation is available on the website, I think that might be everything. It looks like most everybody has taken the poll, so I'm going to go ahead and close that.

Ending that. And Stephanie, I'm going to turn things over to you.

>> Well, thank you very much, Rebecca. I'm delighted to be here with all of you this afternoon. We're going to be talking about why these particular midterm elections matter so much. We're also going to be highlighting some of the key policy issues that are important to individuals with disabilities, including healthcare, Medicaid, employment, and education, and then be talking a little bit about some details of voting.

Technical question, first, Rebecca, is this poll to that's on my screen showing up? Do I need to do something there?

>> You can close that. I don't know why your you're seeing it and I'm not but I thought I closed it so.

>> Okay. Great. Well, let's get started. I'm speaking today on behalf of the National Center of Congress, and NDSC is nonpartisan and works in a

bipartisan way. We do not endorse political parties or candidates, and, in fact, any of you who are working with a nonprofit organization that has a 5013C status should also not be endorsing candidates or parties on behalf of the organization. Although you certainly can do it as an individual, whatever you choose to do.

So the information, the webinar is intended to be informational in nature. I'm not going to be telling you what you should do or who you should vote for, but rather, to highlight some of the key issues of importance and to give you resources so you can further investigate and make your own decisions and hopefully vote on November 6.

NDSC does not have a voter guide and we don't endorse any particular voter guides but many other disability organizations do. I've included a number of links to voter guides and other information here, I'm not endorsing those, in particular. I think you'll find them of interest.

So why is this particular midterm election so important? We have all of the U.S. House of Representatives up for re-election. All 435 seats. A third of the U.S. senators are up, that's 33 senators are up for re-election, the state and local offices, and, more than three quarters of state legislative seats are up in 46 states. That is a pretty massive amount of people who are running for election and the results of this election are going to make a huge difference, particularly for individuals with disabilities.

One of the reasons that the midterm elections are important is there's a potential for a power shift or a flip in the House or the Senate. Currently, the Republicans are in the majority in both the House and the Senate. It's possible that one, the House or the Senate, could shift to the other party. And this is being seen as a referendum on the current political direction of the country.

In the House of representatives, there are only 24 seats that separate the two parties. The Republicans only have 24 more seats than the Democrats. In the Senate, there are only two seats that separate the parties. And as I said, all 435 House seats are up for reelection.

The Democrats are targeting 91 of the GOP held seats, while the House Republicans are targeting 36 Democratic seats. So what's the implication for a divided government? A divided government is when you have the president from one party and at least one party of Congress controlled by the other. And there are folks who believe that there are difficulties to a divided government. The slide says force compromised is saying there's incentive for negotiation because you typically need both parties to get something through. The spending may be more limited and there's checks

on desirable laws. Others feel that divided government is not a good thing, it leads to gridlock.

Currently, as I said, both the executive and the legislative branches are controlled by the same party and that means the cabinet members and the judges tend to be approved, and that bipartisan compromise is disincentivized because the majority party is less likely to need the help of the minority party.

It's really very, very important to be focussing on the state and local elections, as well as the national elections. In recent years, the states have much more control over policy decisions and funding. Many decisions have now been moved or moved to the states, and we'll be talking in a few minutes about a few of those.

The governor, attorneys general, state legislative elections, are all up for grabs. The local governments, your city, or your county, make many different things and decisions that directly affect your life. Some examples are the schools, public safety, the police force, housing issues, public transit, and school boards, of course, are very important. They determine where students are going to school, the districting, the staffing, the budget, and many other decisions that are important to students with disabilities and their families and the teachers and other professionals who work with them.

Now, if you're not quite sure who in your state is up for re-election, you can go to this website and Rebecca will be sharing the PowerPoint with you, so you'll have this information later. You can click on this link and find out exactly who is up for re-election in your state.

So there's many, many issues that impact individuals with disabilities.

We're going to highlight a few of the areas. Healthcare, Medicaid, employment, education, and higher education.

Let's talk about healthcare first. I think do we have a poll for this one no? Not until the next one.

The Affordable Care Act or ACA, sometimes referred to as Obama care, is by no means perfect. There are many challenges with ACA in terms of individuals being able to get affordable coverage, problems in various states, but the approach to have a wholesale repeal of the ACA would be a serious problem for people with disabilities. There have been some things that have been happening to weaken ACA protections for people with disabilities. In December, in the tax bill, the individual mandate was eliminated, that's the requirement that every individual has healthcare coverage, and that has had a negative impact on coverage available to all.

The Administration stopped paying for marketplace strategies last summer which has caused a real strain on the system. And in the following bullet, there's a word missing. It should say short term plans are now being aloud, the agency regulations are allowing plans that do not meet the ACA's coverage requirements and allow people with pre-existing conditions to be charged more. There have been many concerns about these short term plans.

So let's think about what is on the line with healthcare. There has been discussion, the Senate majority leader, McConnell recently indicated that he's interested in another try at a full repeal of the Affordable Care Act on the federal level. And I think we have a poll on this, don't we, Rebecca? No. Not the attorney general one.

>> How, about -- .

>> Yes, the question was, did you contact your member of Congress about repealing the ADA this past summer?

There was a major effort in Congress to repeal the Affordable Care Act. It looked like that repeal was going to go through. But incredible advocacy, much of it done by the disability community, turned that around. And three republican senators voting against it caused that effort to fail. I know that at the national down syndrome Congress, we had a big effort during our convention, we had families and students and others do videos that were then went viral about what the ACA meant to them and encouraging members to vote against it.

I'm seeing here, and we'll keep going with this poll for a minute, that quite a few of you did contact your members of Congress. And every single one of those contacts does make a difference.

At the state level, the governors and state legislators determine the level of funding for healthcare. They also make decisions about how to administer the healthcare marketplaces and exchange, and some attorney generals have filed lawsuits against the federal government to preserve the ACA protections and others have joined in a Texas lawsuit to remove the pre-existing conditions protections.

And we have another poll on that one. So while that's coming up, 41% of you did contact your members of Congress about repealing the ACA. Do you have that other poll handy?

>> Is this it?

>> Yes. Thank you. So the attorney generals -- attorneys general are actually having a big impact on what's going to happen with the ACA. Now, 43 attorneys general are elected, the rest are appointed in some way. So

the first question is, do you know if your attorney general is up for re-election? And secondly, if so, do you know who the candidates are?

So folks want to fill that out while I move along here, that would be great. So these lawsuits are really very important. So it would be if you don't know now, the candidates, up for re-election, who the candidates are, and whether or not they joined this lawsuit against the federal government to preserve the ACA protections or if they join the Texas lawsuit to remove the pre-existing conditions protections. That will be something that's important to find out.

Individuals who have pre-existing conditions,, if it's disability related or other health conditions, is really very, very important. The other coverage that is at risk is there have been movements to change what's considered funding for essential and non essential health benefits. And many things that are considered non essential are critically important to people with disabilities. There's also issues about lifetime and annual caps. To are someone like my daughter who had four open heart operations, if she had been on Medicaid, what would have happened when the fourth heart operation came along and she had met her lifetime caps? That's something that's really being faced by many people.

So we're seeing on the results here that 70% of you know whether or not your attorney general is up for re-election. 14 or 61% know who the candidates are, that's great. I have to tell you I just moved to a new state and I don't know, but I'm going to find out before November 6th. And seven of you know whether the attorney general has joined one of these lawsuits. So I'm glad that we've got so many that are familiar with these things. And if you don't know those answers, those would be good things to find out, and we're going to talk a little bit about how to find out some of those questions.

So let's go to our next slide. So with respect to healthcare, what are some of the questions to ask candidates? And in a few minutes we'll talk about how you can get your questions in. The first one is a very basic question, what is your position on the Affordable Care Act? If you're a senator or a who is up for re-election or you're a House member is currently in Congress, the question is how do they vote in the past?

One of the things that's been interesting the last week we've been seeing articles in the paper about members who said they voted a certain way when actually they voted a different way.

You can go to this [www dot govtrack dot us](http://www.govtrack.us) to find out how the members voted.

If the candidate says they support repealing ACA, whether they're currently in Congress or running. Here's some specific questions, will you fight to maintain health coverage? And if so, how would you do that while repealing the ACA? Do you support lifetime or annual caps?

Now, the ACA does need some improvements. Those improvements, though, would best be done through a thoughtful, bipartisan process that isn't taking a sledge hammer to it.

Another question is, and this is a critically important question, will you fight to maintain health coverage for people with pre-existing conditions?

The current status on Medicaid. One of the things I've found over the years is members of Congress are sometimes not really aware that Medicaid isn't just health coverage, that it provides critically important long-term services and supports, LTSS, to people with disabilities and home and community-based services, HCBS. These are the -- and the waivers that allow individuals to get the support they need to live in a community and to be employed, full are specific proposed cuts to med indicate in the budget and in tax reform legislation, and the Department of Health and human services has been approving state requests that limit Medicaid access. For example, through work requirements. Now, philosophically, it might seem that having a requirement that someone work if they're going to get Medicaid might sound like it makes sense and the word is, well, if you're a person with a disability, it doesn't impact you. But actually yes, it could, when you look at the actual details.

It also impacts caregivers, whether they're family caregivers or others who are providing various types of care.

There are also attempts currently to weaken the home and community-based services rule that has to do with community integration, and weakening that rule could lead to more separate kinds of living situations.

We also have more federal attempts to cap and cut Medicaid, and those are caps on the amount of funds that go to the states which will then cause the state to make very direct services about cutting services, cutting people, and so on.

There's also a possible roll back of state Medicaid coverage to think about, and as I mentioned, the work requirements and other limitations are also in play. And if there is a roll back of the HCBS settings rule, that could lead to more institutionalizations.

AAPD has a voting guide, and there's a link here specifically to the healthcare Medicaid and Medicare positions, and they have very detailed helpful information on these issues.

So what are some questions to ask candidates about Medicaid? I think the first question is do you support or propose block granting and/or per capita caps to Medicaid? The block granting would be sending a certain amount of money to the states and having them make the decisions about how those funds would be used without the current federal guard rails in place. Do you support or oppose work requirements? Time limits or other various -- barriers to eligibility for Medicaid? Do you believe that people with significant disabilities should live in institutions or in the community with support? And for state candidates, those running for governor or a state house or a state assembly, how will you help to reduce the state waiting list for Medicaid LTSS, long-term services and supports? In some states, the parents literally have to die before their adult son or daughter can get the service that is they need.

All right. Let's turn to employment. The workforce innovation opportunity act or, WIOA, is the major employment legislation that governs various types of employment supports and services, as well as vocational rehabilitation services. There has been a strong push by certain members of Congress to what's called open up the WIOA regulations and a specific target is the definition of competitive integrated employment in the regulations. This is something that would be very problematic in the disability community we work for years to get competitive integrated employment as the first option for individuals with disabilities. For the first definition, and it will be very problematic if I can these regulations were opened and this was changed?

The Department of Education has included up opening up the WIOA regulations on a list of regulations that they might revise. And this could also, the definition, in favor of segregated work environments. There are also good legislative efforts to minimize the sub minimum wage that allow individuals with disabilities to be paid less than minimum wage. That's something else that we're keeping a close eye on.

So in the employment area, what questions might you want to ask? Well, the first one is do you support the definition of competitive integrated employment as codified in the workforce innovation opportunity act and the subsequent regulations? That would be an important question for anyone running for Congress.

Do you believe that all people with disabilities should have the opportunity to work at a real job and inclusive setting and earn competitive wages? That really is the plain language version of competitive integrated employment.

Also a question for both federal officials, people running for national office, as well as state office, is what would you do to increase work opportunities for people with disabilities and, again, AAPD has a very helpful section on employment, and you can click on that link to get to it.

I'm going to cover another couple of areas and then we'll open it up for questions.

Let's talk about kindergarten through 12th grade or preschool through 12th grade education and what the current status is. The individuals with disabilities education act or IDEA, which is the federal special education law, is still not fully funded. When the first version of IDEA passed in 1975, Congress made a commitment to fund 40% of the excess cost of educating students with disabilities. We've never reached that number. It's typically in the low teens, 12%, 13%, certainly nowhere near 40%.

We're also concerned that the IDEA discipline guidance that protects against unwarranted suspensions of students with disabilities might be repealed. That's one that's -- that's at risk.

Other IDEA and ESSA, the elementary -- well, it -- it is the main law is called elementary and secondary education act, the ESSA guidance documents and regulations could be rescinded as unnecessary. The Department of Education is currently reviewing all guidance documents and regulations to determine what might be eliminated.

Many state ESSA stands and ESSA is every student succeeds act, many state ESSA plans to not provide sufficient accountability for students with disabilities and many states are assessing too many students using an alternate assessment. Have been a number states that have recently requested a waiver of the rule that only 1% of students and that's equal to 10% of students with disabilities, can be assessed used an alternate assessment. If that's something you have a particular interest in, you can follow the NDSC follows Facebook page, and that information posted on there, and I'll be giving you that link a little later.

It's also very clear that clear provisions of IDEA are not being well implemented, particularly the requirement that students be placed in the least restrictive environment and that is something that is very challenging and it is particularly concerning that it depends on whether you live, whether or not you're not -- you're, you as a student or your child is getting their right to be placed in the least restrictive environment and receive a free appropriate public education. It shouldn't matter what school district or county or state you live in.

Education, what is on the line? If you're considering someone who is currently an incumbent, a U.S. senator, a member of the House of

Representatives, it's important to look at how they've tried to influence the Department of Education, if they have. Have they signed against rolling back and eliminating regulations? Have they pushed for strong state ESSA plans?

Another issue that's important is the possible re-authorization of IDEA. It's actually several years overdue and being re-authorized. But it's not really critical that it be re-authorized right now, and it's my view, and many other disability advocates share the view, that this is the most a good time to re-authorize IDEA. There are too many issues that would be problematic. It's very important to be paying attention to the governor's races and any other elected officials who impact education, school boards and so on. Some of the key issues are teacher pay, ESSA, and IDEA implementation, vouchers, and so on. So some of the questions to ask regarding education, for Congressional candidates are do you support full funding the individuals with disabilities education act? Do you believe that the Department of Education, have problems with subgroups, such as students with disabilities in the say the ESSA plans? And for state candidates, would you review the state ESSA plan and push for stronger accountability for subgroups such as students with disabilities? What would you do to ensure that districts are properly implementing IDEA, especially for students who take alternative assessments? And would you meet with families and students if you're elected to hear from us and work with us to determine what the key issues are with educating students with disabilities and discuss how to address those issues?

Now, it's possible that if you're talking to someone who is running for office for the first time, they might not really be familiar with all of the details of ESSA plans and so on. And you can always offer to follow-up and send them information. It's important to develop relationships early on and continue as members get elected.

Okay. Let's talk for a minute about higher education and then we'll get to any questions we might have in the chat box. So as I think most of you know, in 2008, we were successful in getting the higher education opportunity act amended to allow federal student aid for students with intellectual disabilities who were enrolled in post secondary programs. So for the first time in 2018, students with intellectual disability became eligible for Pell grants, federal supplemental educational opportunity grants and work-study jobs, but not loans. And in HEOA, model demonstration programs were also authorized. These were transition and post secondary programs for students with intellectual disability with the catchy acronym of TPSIDs. We're in the second round of funding for these. We were also to

get a national coordinating center authorized, and that was awarded to a college, and the responsibilities of the NCC are to provide technical assistance, coordination between and evaluation of the TPSID is project, to create recommended model standards and to provide information and technical assistance to students, families, and others. We've also been successful in getting appropriations each year for the TPSIDs and the national coordinating center and that 11.8 million was included in the FY -- the fiscal year 29 operations bill which was just signed by the president. So that's all very good news.

Now let's think about what's on the line in terms of higher education. And this is he focussed on the students with intellectual disability provisions but there's other provision that is are very important to students with did disabilities. We've been working with Congress to ensure that the provisions I've just outlined with improvements stay in the higher education act when it's re-authorized. It is overdue for re-authorization, and both parties have talked about wanting to get that done.

If the TPSID model demos and the national coordinating sent remember not included in the re-authorization, those programs will end.

The House education workforce committee approved the Republican bill HR4508 which does include the current law ID provisions. Unfortunately it does not include some other very important provisions for students with disabilities and personal preparation. The Democratic bill included many improvements to the ID provisions that I discuss, as well as other important disability provisions. That particular bill does not go anywhere. It will depend on who is in control of the House after the election, whether or not the Democratic bill or the Republican bill will be the base bill that they start their discussions and re-authorizations from. In the Senate they worked hard to negotiate a way to have a bipartisan re-authorization. That effort stalled. But the Senate is likely to take up the HEA re-authorization in the next Congress. So two kind of clear, easy to understand questions regarding these ID provisions are do you believe that the programs for students with intellectual disabilities and current law should be included in the higher education act re-authorization? And do you support continuing the current annual funding of 11.8 million for post secondary programs for students with ID in the higher education act? And if you're trying to get someone who is running for office to support something, it's always easier to ask, will you support continuing something as opposed to will you support new funding.

So let's take moment here. Rebecca, do we have any questions about the material that we've covered so far?

>> I have not seen any come in the chat box, but if anyone has any, Stephanie is offering to answer anything right now or questions about things she's discussed so far. But nothing has come in so far.

>> Okay. Well, if you do have questions, we'll be taking more questions at the end.

So now we've talked about the key policy issues and questions to ask, and how do you find out how candidates stand on policy issues? Let's take a quick poll here, Rebecca. How many of you have a good idea of where the candidates stand on key issues? I think you had that poll question you can put up there, Rebecca.

We're starting to get a few responses. You all are quick on the response. Mm-hmm. Let's heave that up there for a moment. Give people a chance to respond. So where are some of the places that you can find out where candidates stand? And I realize we're getting very close to the election. It's coming up November 6th. But there are still ways to find out where the candidates stand on things. For one thing, go to their websites, just Google the candidate's name and they will usually have up there what their priorities are. Sometimes as ambiguous. There are still some town hall meetings going on, candidate forums, those are great places to listen to what they have to say and then also to get in your questions.

There's also Facebook Live sessions where you can ask questions much. Now let's see how we're doing here on. Okay. 56% of you, 15 said you do know where candidates stand or policy issues and 44%, or 12 of you, have said no, so a little more than half do know and that's a good thing.

So in addition to going in person to places you're doing the Facebook Live session, there are some great resources that you can find that highlight specifically disability and civil rights organizations. An example is the respectability report. They've done a questionnaire that candidates have and heed, so you're getting the candidates responses to specific questions, that's a good question. There are also issue specific political action committees or endorsements that can help you understand where someone stands on healthcare or education or so on. And if someone is currently in office, if it is a incumbent, you can go to this www.fdot.gov track dot U.S. website and look at their former statements and voting records. This is Justin dart, one of the heroes of the disability movement, and he's known as the father of the ADA. He was the driving force behind getting that passed, and one of my favorite quotes of Justin is, "vote as if your life depends on it because it does."

Thought you might like to see some photos here of some of my friends, Facebook friends, after they voted. You can see all those great I voted

stickers. Some of you may be familiar with Tuesdays with Liz. That's a weekly video series held by Liz Weintraub who works for AUCD, and this particular one on being an educated voter provides some great information about how to find out where candidates stand on various issues, so I would encourage you to watch this, as well as other Tuesdays with Liz.

Now, as I mentioned, voter guides are also very helpful. And I'm not endorsing any particular one of these, but I found that the AEPD voting guide is very helpful and it has very detailed information on a number of issues.

And then at the state level, there are candidate specific statements.

The ARC has done this sort of thing in various states. This is the link to the ARC Indiana page and they have sent out questionnaires to candidates and then they put together information on how candidates respond on specific statements so you can Google and see if your state has an ARC or other organization candidate specific statement.

Now, let's talk about requirements to vote. You must be a U.S. citizen, whether you were born here or a naturalized citizen, have you to be at least 18 years old, you must be registered in your state by the appropriate deadline, except in North Dakota where no registration is necessary, and if you're not sure if you're registered or not, you can click on this link here and check your registration status. There's been a lot of discussion lately about voter IDs and new voter ID laws. You may need an identification to vote.

Some states require a photo ID. Others will take a utility or phone bill. And you can go to this link by the national conference of state legislators and find the voter requirements in your state. There's another link here that is the course for that information.

If you go to vote and you're told that you're not eligible for some reason to vote, you should ask for a provisional ballot.

Now, these are the deadlines in every state for registering to vote. We've missed most of them. But as you can see, there are still some states that allow you to register up to election day and there's a few others where still like Nebraska where it is still possible to register but go quickly if you are in Nebraska.

Now, this may seem obvious but let's talk about how to vote. Obviously you can go in person to your poll, polling place, on November 6th. Let's have a little poll up here, Rebecca, how many people know where their polling place is? While they put that up, I'll keep going. Now, some states have early voting, I live in North Carolina now, and they allow you to go in and vote early. As some states are as much as 45 days early. And the

early voting, though, might be at a different polling place in your usual voting.

You can also vote by absentee ballot. Usually those applications are available on-line. In some states they have a no excuses ballot. You don't have to say why you're sending in absentee ballot. In other cases have you to justify, for instance, I'll be out of town and I'll be in Canada that day or whatever. There are a few states, Oregon, Washington, and Colorado, and also some California counties, that mail ballots to register voters and then you can either return those by mail or add at a voting place.

Wow. 97% of you said that you know where your polling place is. That's terrific. We obviously have a well-informed group here.

So here's a few things to consider about voting. As I said, it's not too late to register in some states, and there's a link here to find out about your state deadline. If you're not sure if you're registered or not, you can go to this link and check if your registration is still valid.

If you want to know what your state's requirements are to vote, a good thing to check on so you don't get turned away at the policy, you can go to this link to check on your state's requirement. Well 97% of you know where your polling place is. If you don't know where your poll place is or you have a friend who doesn't know where their polling place is, you can go to the league of women voters website to find out the polling place. They also have very helpful voters guides. Then if you need the absentee ballot, there's the source to register the absentee ballot and you can go to the turbo vote to do that.

So an important caution is that selfies with ballots are illegal in many states. You may have seen news coverage lately about people who have been getting in trouble for early voting, they're subject to fines. Many states do not allow phones or electronics inside the polling place, so be careful about that. And the laws are unclear in many states. So you can go to that link to find out.

Here's Frank Stevens here with his I voted sticker. Take those photos outside the polling place. And sometimes they'll even set up special places for people to do their selfies with their I voted stickers.

Now, let's take about individuals with disabilities voting. The unfortunately the voter turn out rate for people with disabilities was 6% lower than people without disabilities during the 2016 election, and we need to make sure that that doesn't happen again.

Now, some individuals who may be hearing-impaired or blind need -- and other situations need physical access to voting and we'll get to a slide on the ADA shortly. If you or someone you care about has a cognitive

disability, then there may be a need to provide assistance about understanding policy issues and what's at stake. One of the national Congress of self-advocates and the policy team put together a add vole see guide for self-advocates and there's a link here that can be very helpful.

There are some problems in some states in someone has -- if there is full guardian ship for a person with a disabilities, their votes -- their right to vote is restricted in some states, and the Basilon center in collaboration with, center and they've pout putt together a guide for the voting rights of people with mental disabilities which is very help.. However, guardianship doesn't does not automatically mean you can't vote. So it's important to check on that.

There's some great disability voter campaigns, including the RevUp campaign. And I've put a link there to that.

And there's some good voting resources for persons with disabilities, and there's a link here to the University of Montana resource list.

>> Stephanie, I just want to interrupt for one second if it's okay. Somebody did actually just ask about guardian ship and the question was, if parents were guardianship with adult children with disabilities, it's is it possible that the judge can rule that a individual cannot vote?

>> In some states, and I can't address that for all states, there is a list of items and the person who is requesting guardian ship can say, for instance, that they want the person to maintain the right to vote. So it wouldn't be a full guardian ship, it would be a guardian ship except on that issue. Or it might be that there's guardianship for certain issues like legal and health decisions but not for other issues.

>> And if that didn't answer your question, Jennifer, please just, you know, you can ask something again. And actually, another question just came in about guardian ship under knowing how to know the policy in a certain state, somebody is asking about the policy for guardianship voting in Massachusetts, for example. So does each state have its own --

>> Each state has their own rules about guardianship, and I don't happen to know the rules in Massachusetts. One way to find out if a guardianship has been obtained through an attorney is to check with the attorney's office. Often the AR in a state will have information about that. There are also organizations related to supported decision making and if you Google supported decision making, you'll find information about that as well as guardian ship in a state. So I'm sorry I don't know the specifics about the law in Massachusetts.

Any other at this point?

>> Not that I'm seeing right now. Thank you.

Here's a link to AAPD's RevUp campaign. They have some great resources, state resources, tool kits, issue guides, and accessibility tool kit, and much more. So that's one you might want to check out.

Now, let's talk about the Americans with Disabilities Act. There are some very specific voting rights under the ADA, and I'm not going to read each of these, but, you know, have you the right to vote privately and independently. There's some issues related to physical access such as wheelchair accessibility, I have thing equipment that's accessible to voters who are blind or have low vision, being able to take a service animal in with you. You're also allowed to seek assistance from workers at the polling place who have been trained to use accessible voting machine. And something that people don't always know is that you can bring someone with you to help you to vote, including it could be a family member, a friend, a caregiver, or almost anyone else, but not your employer or a union representative. And what I found with my daughter is that when she signed in, she'd say I need my mom to help me and I was able to assist her in the voting booth. Now, she always made up her own mind about who she was going to vote for, it wasn't always the same person I was going to vote for, but I provided assistance in how to operate the machine.

If you're at a polling place and you feel your rights are being violated, there's the toll free number here that you can call.

So let's talk about some general tips and reminders. Whoever gets elected, that person still represents you, whether you voted for them or not. And whomever is elected, it's important that they hear from and understand the key issues that are important to the voters. Typically one is more successful in getting their point across if they're respectful and professional in social media postings and in public messaging, negativity towards the individual person can come back and bite you. And that means no personal attacks on candidates.

You know, we, at NDSC, recommend trying to educate and inform the candidates, and typically, I found that if you focus on how this issue impacts me and my family, what does this mean for me, people tend to not have a bad feeling or viewpoint towards someone who is saying how something impacts them personally and their family. So here's some ideas on how to get involved on election day.

Consider volunteering at the poll. Providing transportation to the polls. This is particularly for people who have difficulty getting places. Become an election poll worker, assisting the polling place, assisting voters, getting involved in the campaign, and finding out who is on your ballot, there's a

link for that there. And as I said earlier, it's important for anyone representing a nonprofit, 501c organization to not endorse a candidate or a party. As an individual, though, you certainly have every right to do that. And one of the ways that I have personally found to be very effective in getting a candidate's ear is to attend one of their fund-raising events. Now, I wouldn't attend a fund-raising event for someone I wouldn't consider voting for. But that's a great way to get somebody's attention and to have them remember you if you're having trouble getting answers to the questions they've discussed.

I would like to encourage you to sign up to get the NDSC policy and advocacy news line e-mails. You can see those there. And the action alert, we're very active on Facebook. And try to be very timely and always accurate. And we would love to have you like our Facebook page and follow it, as well as the Twitter and policy update.

At NDSU we also have a new grassroots advocacy campaign that is being used to educate individuals with down syndrome, family members, and other allies, so you don't have to have a family member with down syndrome to provide this advocacy network. We provide advocacy tools. It's a way for advocates across the country to stay in touch with each other in a closed Facebook group, and it's open to individuals of all abilities and levels of advocacy experience. We have quarterly update webinars and provide other resources. If you're interested, that's the link to sign-up.

And I've included my e-mail address here if there's something that you'd prefer to e-mail to me privately about, I'd be happy to respond to you. And we're -- we have about five minutes left here if we have any other questions or comments in the chat box. Or if you'd like to type something in.

>> Thank you, Stephanie. I've shared the questions that have come in.

Another way that you can stay connected, I'm sharing with the group, I just put the link to we have a public policy affinity group at Think College which is a group of people, anyone is welcome to join, they meet quarterly and discuss kind of usually a different topic every time but it's a great way to stay connected with what Think college is doing and it is led by Denny's who is the policy, I never remind her exact title, AUCD centers or disabilities, she's one of our partners and I know her and Stephanie work a lot together on different things.

>> Yes. We do. And I'm a member of the public policy affinity group and I find it very helpful, particularly on issues involving post secondary education.

>> I did just get a question about whether there will be a summary of the webinar which is a really good question. I don't know, I'm just -- I'm just

answering this outloud, Erin, so that if others have the same question, we usually post on our website, there's a brief description right now, and Stephanie's PowerPoint is there, and then we'll post the transcript and the recording. I don't know if you were thinking of something besides that or so if yes, maybe send me an e-mail and we'll see what we can get for you. I don't know if Stephanie, if you have any other suggestions for a place that you would go for a person to get a quick round down or I know you shared a lot of links and things in your webinar but --

>> I think probably the most helpful thing is the webinar is going to be available, correct?

>> Yes. I should be able to post it tomorrow but --

>> Right. So I think the best thing is click through and so say you're interested in healthcare, just click through to the healthcare part, if you're interested in, you know, how do I find out where my candidate stands, just click through to that page. In other words, you don't have to sit and listen to the whole hour. You can just click through the slides. Is that correct, Rebecca?

>> Yes, I mean, you do have to move to the not cursor but, you know, move the slides along.

>> Right.

>> According, move them along yourself.

Someone else asked a really good question about whether, the exact question is with does why you are advocacy effort have issues about materials written at a lower reading level? So that sounds to me like, Beth, you're asking if you mean like a facts sheet or something about --

>> Well, let me -- let me answer that. I had mentioned the tool kit for self-advocates which actually we've been hearing from people who are not self-advocate, they find very helpful too. And we have that was written by a self-advocate with the policy team and I think that's a document that would be helpful in advocacy.

It's always such a challenge and we try with our Facebook post to write things in plain English. There's always this balance between, you know, wanting to put in the name of the laws and not, you know, overdoing using words like provision or being a row nips or whatever that we try our best to achieve. Don't always succeed in, it I have to be honest.

>> That was a good question. And thank you, Stephanie for --

>> Let me also say that the autistic self advocacy network, they do things in two ways, usually. The more detailed context brief reports, whatever, and then one that is more likely to be understood.

>> That's great.

>> While we're wrapping up and if anyone else has questions, please continue to put them in the Q&A or the chat box, I'm going to ask people who are still here, if you don't mind, to do an evaluation course for us on today's webinar to help our presenters know how well they did and to help think College know what we can do differently or better in providing information to all of you. So I just put the webinar up on the screen, if you could take a minute and answer these couple of questions, we would be really grateful. And what else can I say while we're thinking about this. We hope you vote. We keep sharing a lot on think College's social media pages about voting, so hopefully you'll be able to do that. And hopefully today's webinar was really helpful. If you're not on our mailing list or following us on social media, please consider doing, that we have a bunch of webinars coming up, we have one more scheduled so far this year, the calendar year, but in January, through June, I think there are eight on all kinds of topics. So check out our website and see what we have.

>> Stephanie, anything else you would like to say in closing?

>> Beyond vote.

>> Right. Vote.

>> I would like to thank everyone for hanging on to the end here and for your interest and engagement.

>> Yeah. It was a good group. Good questions. And we are grateful, at think College we're grateful for all of you who are attending as well. So thank you, and feel free. A few people asked about sharing stuff. Please do. I'm sure Stephanie would appreciate you sharing this information with family groups, teacher groups, community groups, anybody about voting and being educated. So share all of this information as you would like. And it's 2 o'clock exactly now so I'm going to say thank you again and we'll see you at our next webinar, I hope. Thank you again, Stephanie, for being here today.

>> Thanks, everyone.